

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action 2026 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Syrak Micael

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council District 7

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including a San Pablo Specific Plan and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. San Pablo specific plan
- b. Zoning for housing in high-resource commercial areas like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave
- c. Extending 'middle housing' zoning to some parts of the Hills, while balancing fire risk
- d. Other strategies for Berkeley to affirmatively further fair housing

Broadly, I believe that we need to be building more housing at all income levels, with a specific focus on affordable and below market rate (BMR) housing units, and with priority given to transit-rich areas like those specified in SB 79 (2025). The most important aspect is that all areas of the city are contributing their share to new housing units and especially to new affordable units. I support the bus lane plan on San Pablo Avenue, which I believe will make it easier for residents to move around without a car, and bring more potential customers to the businesses along that corridor.

I support targeted upzoning of high-resource commercial areas, which I believe can be done in a way as to not displace small businesses, but instead bring more foot-traffic to those shops by virtue of there being more people living close to them. I also support a commercial vacancy tax to deter predatory behavior from commercial landlords and to incentivize new development in a way that is consistent with preserving the businesses that are part of what makes these areas worth visiting.

I believe in middle housing in the Hills outside of extreme fire risk areas like Panoramic Hill. Every part of our City must do its part to help bring new units, and especially new affordable units, onto the market, and I believe we can do so while balancing fire risk.

Beyond these specific neighborhoods, I support revenue measures to construct new affordable units and make existing units permanently affordable. While inclusionary zoning and affordability requirements can be helpful to bring new affordable units online, we cannot rely on it entirely and must provide additional sources of public funding to ensure we meet our affordable housing targets.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

I support Berkeley's Climate Action Plan but believe that it does not go far enough. At the local level, the top priority for addressing climate change needs to be reducing vehicle miles traveled (VMT) by helping residents and visitors get where they need to go without relying on a car. Broadly, I want to accomplish this goal through the following strategies:

- *Increasing transit-oriented development: More people should be able to live near transportation hubs.*
- *Improving speed and reliability of public transit: Increase our City's network of dedicated bus lanes and their enforcement. Implement signal priority for buses so bus riders spend less time waiting at red lights. Support the Connect Bay Area initiative to ensure reliable funding streams for transit.*
- *Car-free Telegraph: Reserve the four blocks of Telegraph Avenue south of Bancroft for pedestrians and buses. We must create more public spaces not dominated by cars.*
- *Expanding bike lanes: I am proud of our City's robust network of protected bike lanes and boulevards, but we can do better. I want to work towards a City where car-free alternatives are more viable than driving.*
- *Increasing access to bikes and ebikes: The City has in the past put funding towards a lottery for ebikes for low income residents. I support expanding that program.*
- *Expanding tree cover and urban greening to reduce urban heat island effects and increase shade, which will make it more pleasant to walk and bike around Berkeley.*

I would also like to explore ways to reduce commercial and residential dependence on natural gas. While I was disappointed that the city did not appeal the 9th Circuit's decision to strike down a ban on gas stoves in new residential construction, we must revisit alternative legal strategies to prevent new construction from including natural gas and create incentives to move away from natural gas. In the same vein, I was disappointed at the intense opposition that 2024's Measure GG drew. Despite its defeat, the need to decarbonize and electrify has only

increased. I want to work with stakeholders to find a path forward to decarbonizing commercial buildings through a carrot and stick approach: that is, providing incentives to those who decarbonize and levying fees on those who do not.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

I see our City's Demolition Ordinance as the most important vote over the last four years. I am proud of its protections for tenants and that it enables new construction. Furthermore, this Ordinance removes some of the tension between new development and protecting existing tenants, reducing political opposition to new construction.

If elected, I will continue to push for solutions that allow us to build new affordable units and welcome new residents while protecting existing residents from displacement pressures that may come with new construction.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

Transportation emissions are our city's largest source of greenhouse gas emissions. I believe that our city's collective push to expand pedestrian and bike infrastructure is the most important environmental action taken, and that the city's environmental actions are irreducible to a single vote. I support street design that improves pedestrian and bicycle safety, including protected bike lanes, and am disappointed that certain bike lanes have become a cultural flash point to the extent that they have.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

I am a strong proponent of transit-oriented development, especially the plans to build at Ashby and North Berkeley BART stations, as well as new developments that are now legal under SB

79. I firmly believe that when we welcome new residents, they should be able to get around without a car.

As I describe in my answer to Question 2, I support a number of interventions and policy solutions that make public transportation, walking, and biking increasingly viable alternatives to driving. The majority of residents in my district, Berkeley's Southside, do not own a car and do not need one. I aim to make that true for as many Berkeley residents and visitors as possible. We can design our city in a way that preferences alternative transport over cars.

I also want to work with AVA community energy to ensure that tenant households can access the benefits of renewable energy in the same way that homeowners can. New construction should be carbon-neutral as much as possible, but renters are typically unable to install rooftop solar or access other sustainability interventions like heat pumps and insulation retrofitting.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets?

Pedestrian and cyclist safety is a tantamount concern for me, and I strongly believe in a Vision Zero plan for Berkeley. The majority of residents of my district do not own a car and I want to keep it that way. As I describe above, I want to push for a number of policy interventions that make walking and biking safer than they currently are, which will make them more attractive alternatives to driving.

Specifically in my district, I want to make the four blocks of Telegraph Avenue car-free. To this end, I am proud to be endorsed by the organization Telegraph for People and I look forward to continuing to work with them if elected.

I was proud to see Measure FF (2024, Safe Streets) pass overwhelmingly. While I believe that driver education has a role to play, we must properly design the City we want to see. That means implementing proven safety interventions citywide, including: raised crosswalks, narrower streets ("road diets"), eliminating slip lanes, pedestrian bulb-outs/curb extensions, protected bike lanes, round rectangular flashing beacons (RRFBs), leading pedestrian intervals for stoplights, and speed bumps. I would like to explore the idea of creating a "congestion zone" for the densest parts of Southside, analogous to New York City's congestion pricing for lower Manhattan. As a Councilmember, I intend to work hand in hand with cyclist and pedestrian safety advocates to push these safety interventions and others that they advocate for that I have not explicitly listed here.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

I support inclusionary zoning, and believe it is necessary for desegregating neighborhoods and atoning for our City's troubled history of using zoning for racially exclusionary purposes. I believe we need an all-of-the-above approach to addressing our shortage of affordable housing, and believe that in-lieu fees can be put to a good purpose to make existing sites permanently affordable or to construct new, permanently affordable housing. I think a mix of on site and in-lieu fees is healthy for the city, allowing us to both raise revenue for direct investment while still creating socioeconomic integration in new construction. Some neighborhoods benefit more from one over the other; in-lieu fees make more sense in the Southside for student buildings, but inclusionary units play a critical antidisplacement role in South Berkeley, and serve to integrate wealthier neighborhoods.

Ultimately, we are not going to be able to meet our affordable housing targets unless we pay for it. I support additional revenue measures to fund construction and preservation of affordable units so we don't need to rely exclusively on in-lieu fees. One of these revenue sources could be a commercial vacancy tax, which discourages predatory behavior from commercial landlords, and the revenue from which can fund the construction or preservation of affordable units.